

20 Laban

Rebekah's brother and Jacob's father-in-law, a shrewd host who met his match.

Laban lived in Haran, in Padanaram, far to the north of Canaan. He was Rebekah's brother, Jacob's uncle, and the father of Leah and Rachel. He first appears welcoming Abraham's servant, who had come for a wife for Isaac. Years later he welcomed Jacob, who had fled from Esau. Laban gave Jacob work, two wives and a home, but tricked him on his wedding night and changed his wages again and again. In the end God warned Laban not to harm Jacob, and they parted with a covenant of peace. God kept his promise to Jacob even in a hard household.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Lavan</i> , meaning "white"
Family	Son of Bethuel; brother of Rebekah (Genesis 24:15, 29)
Children	Leah, Rachel, and sons who are not named (Genesis 29:16; 31:1)
Called	"Laban the Syrian," that is, the Aramean (Genesis 25:20; 31:20)
Home	Haran in Padanaram, northern Mesopotamia (Genesis 27:43; 28:2)
Key people	Abraham's servant, Rebekah, Jacob, Leah, Rachel
Main passages	Genesis 24:29–60; 29:1–31:55
New Testament	Not named

"The LORD watch between me and thee, when we are absent one from another."

Genesis 31:49, KJV

The life of Laban

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Laban. The order below follows the text. Jacob's stay with him lasted twenty years (Genesis 31:38, 41).

In Haran	● Welcomes Abraham's servant Seeing Rebekah's gold earring and bracelets, Laban runs out: "Come in, thou blessed of the LORD." <i>Genesis 24:28-33</i>
In Haran	● Lets Rebekah go Laban and Bethuel agree, "The thing proceedeth from the LORD," and Rebekah goes to marry Isaac. <i>Genesis 24:50-61</i>
Many years later	● Welcomes Jacob Laban runs to meet his fleeing nephew: "Surely thou art my bone and my flesh." <i>Genesis 29:13-14</i>
After seven years	● Swaps the brides Jacob serves seven years for Rachel. At the wedding Laban brings Leah instead, then gives Rachel a week later in exchange for seven more years of work. <i>Genesis 29:18-30</i>
Jacob's twenty years	● Changes the wages Laban admits the LORD has blessed him for Jacob's sake. He agrees to Jacob's wages, then removes the animals that would have been Jacob's share. Jacob says his wages were changed "ten times." <i>Genesis 30:25-36; 31:7, 41</i>
On the third day	● Pursues Jacob Jacob slips away with his family and flocks while Laban is shearing sheep. Laban chases him for seven days, but God warns him in a dream not to harm Jacob. <i>Genesis 31:19-35</i>
Mount Gilead	● Makes a covenant The two men set up a pillar and a heap of stones as a witness and a boundary. Early next morning Laban kisses his grandchildren and daughters, blesses them, and goes home. <i>Genesis 31:43-55</i>

Key activities

In Genesis 30:27 the KJV says Laban had "learned by experience" that God blessed him through Jacob. The Hebrew word often means "to practise divination," so some translate it "I have divined." Genesis 31:53 also hints that Laban honored other gods alongside the God of Abraham.

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- 1 Welcomed a stranger.** He ran to meet Abraham's servant and gave him lodging and food for his camels. *Genesis 24:29-32*

 - 2 Agreed to Rebekah's marriage.** He saw the LORD's hand in the servant's story and let his sister go to Isaac. *Genesis 24:50-51*

 - 3 Took Jacob into his home.** He received his nephew and asked him to name his wages. *Genesis 29:13-15*

 - 4 Deceived Jacob.** He gave Leah in place of Rachel and defended it: "It must not be so done in our country, to give the younger before the firstborn." *Genesis 29:22-26*

 - 5 Grew rich through Jacob.** His small flock increased greatly while Jacob cared for it. *Genesis 30:27-30*

 - 6 Tried to keep what was Jacob's.** He removed the spotted and speckled animals and set three days' journey between his flocks and Jacob's. *Genesis 30:31-36*

 - 7 Heard God's warning.** God told him in a dream, "Take heed that thou speak not to Jacob either good or bad." *Genesis 31:24, 29*

 - 8 Searched for his household gods.** He hunted through the tents for his missing images but did not find them, because Rachel had hidden them. *Genesis 31:30-35*

 - 9 Made peace.** He and Jacob swore a covenant, ate together, and agreed not to cross the boundary to harm each other. *Genesis 31:44-54*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Laban.

Old Testament

Genesis 24:29–60	Laban welcomes the servant and sends Rebekah
Genesis 27:43	Rebekah sends Jacob to "Laban my brother to Haran"
Genesis 29:1–31:55	Jacob's twenty years with Laban
Genesis 32:4	"I have sojourned with Laban"
Hosea 12:12	"For a wife he kept sheep"
Echo: Genesis 27:18–29	The deceiver deceived in turn

New Testament

Echo: Galatians 6:7	"Whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap"
Echo: Matthew 6:24	No one can serve God and mammon

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Laban say when Jacob accused him of deceit (Genesis 29:25–27)?
2. *Understand:* Laban was blessed because of Jacob, yet kept cheating him. Why didn't gratitude change him?
3. *Apply:* God saw Jacob's mistreatment (Genesis 31:42). Where do you need to trust God with something unfair?
4. *Apply:* Is there a relationship where a clear, fair boundary would help keep the peace?